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Design and Fabrication of a Reliable Dual Recovery System for the N4 Rocket with Extended Telemetry Range

(FYP22-4)

Interim Report

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February 28, 2026

Declaration

We declare that this interim report is our original work and has not been presented for examination in any other institution.

We confirm that all sources of information, data, and published material used in preparing this report have been appropriately acknowledged and referenced in accordance with university academic standards.

We further affirm that this report reflects the progress made in our Final Year Project at this stage and that the work presented is a true account of the activities completed to date.

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Abstract

The Nakuja N4 rocket recovery system addresses three failure modes identified in previous missions: insufficient telemetry range, uncontrolled nichrome-wire burnout during parachute deployment, and absence of pre-flight electrical status feedback. This interim report presents the design, analysis, and fabrication-stage results achieved to date.

The telemetry subsystem adopts the XBee-PRO 900HP operating at 900 MHz in transparent UART mode, with a first-order link budget confirming a +32 dB margin at 5 km using omnidirectional dipole antennas. The ignition subsystem replaces the previous direct DC dump with PWM-controlled IRLZ44N MOSFET switching at 1 kHz; bench characterisation of 26 AWG nichrome elements demonstrated sustained energisation for approximately 30 seconds at minimum duty cycle compared to burnout within 2 seconds at DC-equivalent drive, validating the controlled-heating approach. A battery monitoring and continuity-detection circuit centred on the ADS1115 16-bit ADC provides pre-launch voltage and igniter-state visibility. Mechanically, a stepped PETG battery-carrier architecture accommodates four 18650 cells within the 95 mm avionics bay while routing dual threaded retention rods without interference.

At the close of this interim phase, all subsystem designs have been completed and verified through 2D/3D CAD, EasyEDA PCB schematics, and Proteus circuit simulation. A custom flight-computer PCB is currently in fabrication, and 3D-printed structural parts are in production. Firmware modules for telemetry, sensor interfacing, PWM control, and flight-state management have been implemented on FreeRTOS. Pending work for the next phase includes PCB assembly, open-field XBee range testing, hardware-level monitoring calibration, and pyrotechnic pop tests to validate deployment force.

Keywords: Rocket recovery system, XBee-PRO 900HP, PWM ignition control,

nichrome wire, dual parachute deployment, ESP32, avionics bay, N4 rocket

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Nomenclature

Abbreviations

ADC Analog-to-Digital Converter

AGL Above Ground Level

BMS Battery Management System

CAD Computer-Aided Design

ESP32 Espressif 32-bit Microcontroller Platform

FEA Finite Element Analysis

GPS Global Positioning System

IMU Inertial Measurement Unit

LiPo Lithium Polymer Battery

MOSFET Metal-Oxide-Semiconductor Field-Effect Transistor

PWM Pulse Width Modulation

RF Radio Frequency

UART Universal Asynchronous Receiver-Transmitter

Symbols and Units

D Duty cycle, percent

f Frequency, hertz

I Current, ampere

P Power, watt

R Resistance, ohm

T Temperature, degree Celsius

V Voltage, volt

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background of Study

Rocket recovery systems represent the most critical subsystem for preserving flight data and hardware in high-power rocketry missions. The evolution of recovery systems has progressed from simple single deployment methods to sophisticated dual deployment architectures. Single deployment systems release a parachute at apogee, presenting risks of high drift radius and unpredictable landing zones. In contrast, dual deployment systems utilize a drogue parachute at apogee for stability, followed by a main parachute deployment at lower altitude for controlled soft landing, establishing the standard for modern high-power rocketry operations.

The Nakuja Project N4 mission builds upon previous experiences from the N3.5 mission, which employed a basic single-deployment piston-based system. The current N4 design implements dual deployment architecture but faces significant challenges in deployment reliability and telemetry signal integrity. Previous missions demonstrated critical vulnerabilities in both mechanical deployment mechanisms and communication systems, necessitating a comprehensive redesign approach.

1.2 Problem Statement

The N4 mission's recovery system faces critical reliability challenges including telemetry range limitations causing signal degradation during critical flight phases, uncontrolled ignition system temperatures exceeding 1000 degrees Celsius that create unreliable single-use deployment mechanisms, and absence of real-time pre-flight monitoring systems for battery voltage and igniter continuity, collectively threatening mission success through potential vehicle loss, deployment failures, and inability to validate system readiness before launch.

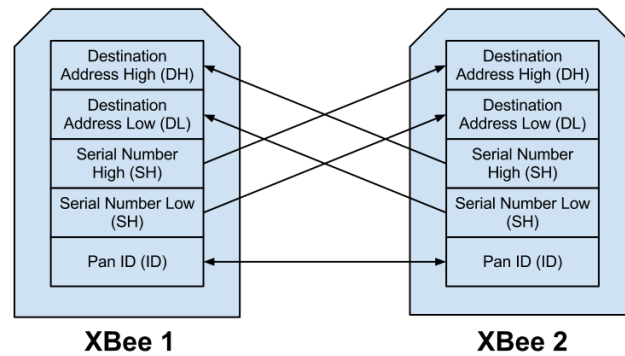


Figure 1: XBee-PRO 900HP telemetry integration architecture used to improve end-to-end link reliability

1.3 Objectives

Main Objective: To design, fabricate, and validate a reliable dual deployment recovery system for the N4 rocket with extended telemetry range and comprehensive pre-flight monitoring capabilities.

Specific Objectives:

1. Implement the Digi XBee-PRO 900HP telemetry system for long-range communication.
 2. Develop a controlled ignition system for consistent parachute deployment.
 3. Implement an explosion-cap assisted deployment arrangement to improve pop-test repeatability and deployment reliability.
 4. Establish thermochemical verification curves to justify adiabatic explosion behavior and motivate contained deployment design.
 5. Integrate real-time pre-flight monitoring for battery and igniter continuity status.
 6. Validate the integrated recovery subsystem through ground-based testing.
-

1.4 Justification

The development of a reliable recovery system is paramount to mission success. Loss of the rocket vehicle results not only in hardware loss but also complete loss of flight data critical for mission analysis and future design improvements. The proposed improvements address documented failure modes from previous missions and implement industry-standard practices adapted for student rocketry applications.

The Nakuja Project represents a significant investment in student engineering education and practical aerospace systems development. Ensuring mission success through robust recovery systems validates this investment and provides valuable learning opportunities for future engineering professionals.

1.5 Expected Outcomes

The expected outcomes of this study are:

1. Reliable telemetry performance beyond 5 km with packet loss maintained below 5%.
 2. Controlled PWM-based igniter operation that prevents nichrome burnout and supports repeated ground testing.
 3. Improved deployment repeatability from an explosion-cap based pop-test method with reduced ignition variability.
 4. Thermochemical evidence curves showing near-adiabatic charge behavior to support contained deployment requirements.
 5. Verified real-time pre-flight status monitoring for battery health and igniter continuity.
 6. Improved deployment reliability through a sealed explosion-cap arrangement and ruggedized avionics mounting.
-

-
7. A validated subsystem integration and test framework to support final flight-readiness evaluation.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Recovery Systems in Student Rocketry

Recovery systems preserve flight hardware and flight data and are therefore mission-critical in high-power student rocketry [1,2]. A common practice is dual deployment: a drogue parachute at apogee for stability and reduced drift, then a main parachute at lower altitude for lower landing energy. Literature consistently shows that this staged strategy improves recovery reliability compared with single-deployment approaches in high-altitude missions.

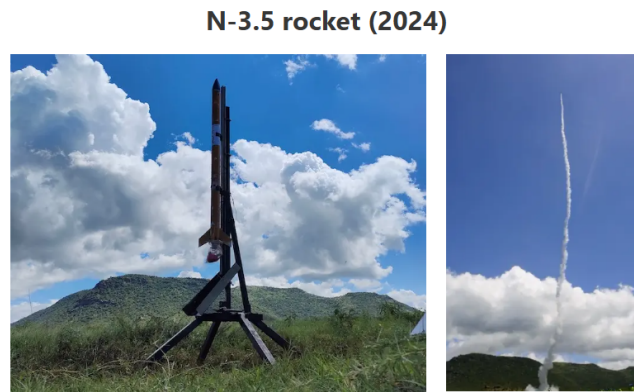


Figure 2: Full Nakuja N3 rocket showing the dual-deployment recovery configuration and component layout

The Nakuja project progression from earlier single-deployment flights to N4 dual deployment reflects this broader trend and responds to observed mission-level constraints in communication and recovery robustness [3].

2.2 Telemetry Systems Analysis

Table 1 compares telemetry options reported in student rocketry and related field systems.

Comparative studies show a tradeoff between range, bandwidth, protocol reli-

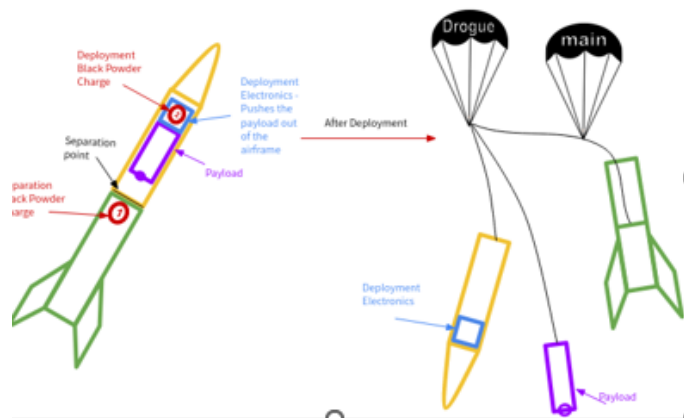


Figure 3: Rocket in flight demonstrating the dual-deployment sequence and aerodynamic stability during ascent

Table 1: Telemetry System Comparison for Student Rocketry Applications

Technology	Range	Data Cap	Strength	Limitation
433 MHz RF	5–10 km	Very low	Simple, long range	No ACKs
Beacon	4 km/0.8 km	Low–Med	Simple	Range drops
LoRa SX1278	2–15 km	Low	Low power	Low BW
XBee 2.4 GHz	<2 km	Medium	Easy integration	Short range
XBee-PRO 900HP	5–15 km	Med–High	Reliable	Higher power
ESP-NOW	<1 km	Medium	Low latency	Not long-range
Cellular LTE	Global	High	Unlimited range	Network dep.

ability, and implementation complexity [4]. 900 MHz-class links are often favored for long-range recovery because of better propagation in non-ideal field conditions compared with higher-frequency short-range links [5].

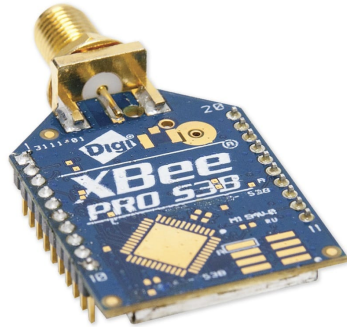


Figure 4: XBee radio module used as the long-range telemetry transceiver platform

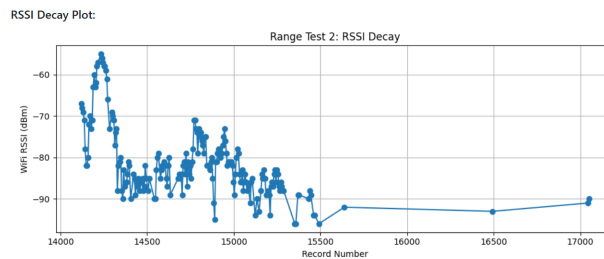


Figure 5: Beacon RSSI decay analysis showing signal degradation with distance and altitude

2.2.1 Antenna Options in Recovery Telemetry

Literature and field practice show several antenna families for rocket telemetry ground/air links: dipole and whip (omnidirectional, low complexity), patch and Bi-Quad (moderate gain, directional), and Yagi arrays (higher gain, tighter pointing requirement) [6,7]. For dynamic flight profiles, antenna pattern behavior and polarization stability are as important as nominal gain.



Figure 6: 900 MHz duck antenna used in the N4 telemetry configuration

Published antenna fundamentals highlight two recurring operational issues in flight telemetry links: axis nulls in dipole-like patterns and polarization mismatch during vehicle attitude change [7]. These effects can dominate performance even when radio modules have adequate power margins.

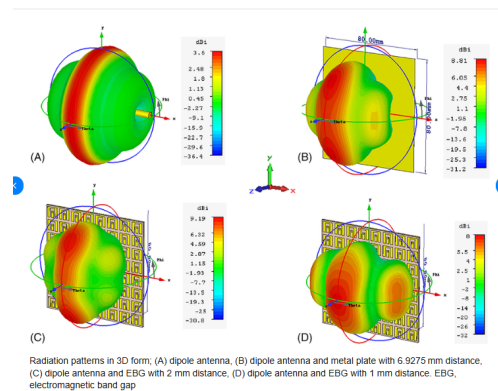


Figure 7: Dipole radiation “donut” pattern illustrating nulls along the antenna axis

Antenna-related gaps from literature and field use:

- Limited student-focused procedures for selecting antenna type versus expected flight geometry.
- Limited quantified comparison of omnidirectional versus directional ground

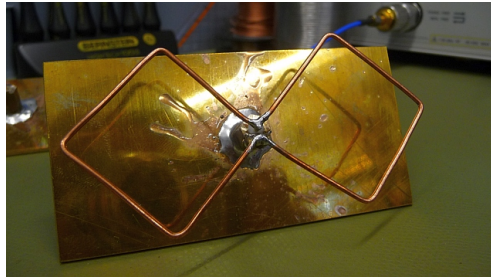


Figure 8: Example 900 MHz Bi-Quad ground-station antenna option for improved link margin

antennas under real recovery scenarios.

- Inadequate treatment of polarization mismatch during descent spin/tumble in student mission workflows.

2.3 Pyrotechnic Deployment and Ignition Control

Black-powder deployment remains a common separation/ejection method in amateur and student rocketry, but reliability depends on predictable charge energy, charge containment, venting behavior, and material thermal tolerance [1,8]. Literature also distinguishes between commercial e-match igniters and custom nichrome approaches, with tradeoffs in repeatability, cost, and field test convenience [9].

For resistive igniters, literature reports that uncontrolled energy delivery can cause premature wire failure or inconsistent ignition behavior, while controlled-energy strategies improve repeatability [9–11].

Repeated nichrome-wire pop tests in field programs commonly encounter partial melting, embrittlement, and breakage, reducing re-usability and forcing frequent replacement cycles [9,12]. This motivates more repeatable ignition interfaces, including contained explosion-cap style arrangements that decouple ignition repeatability from wire survivability [8,12].

Combustion literature further shows that short-duration pyrotechnic events

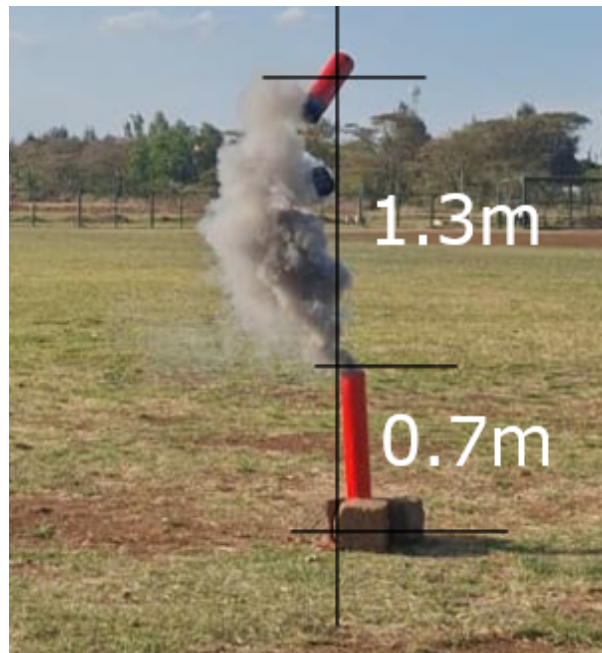


Figure 9: Excessive crimson powder deployment showing the need for precise charge control



Figure 10: Charge holder thermal damage from explosion highlighting thermal isolation requirements



Figure 11: Post-deployment test showing charring effects and the importance of sealed containment



Figure 12: Cut nichrome wire after pop testing, highlighting a key re-usability limitation in direct-wire ignition approaches

are often modeled as near-adiabatic transients for first-order chamber estimates, making thermal/pressure curves essential for validating containment assumptions and charge-holder boundaries [13, 14]. This directly supports contained deployment architectures for safer and more predictable pop-test behavior.

Pyrotechnic-deployment gaps from literature and field use:

- Limited mission-specific charge mass versus ejection effectiveness data for student airframe geometries.
- Limited standardized procedures for chamber-seal verification before live deployment tests.
- Limited quantified comparison between e-match and nichrome-based systems under repeated ground-test cycles.

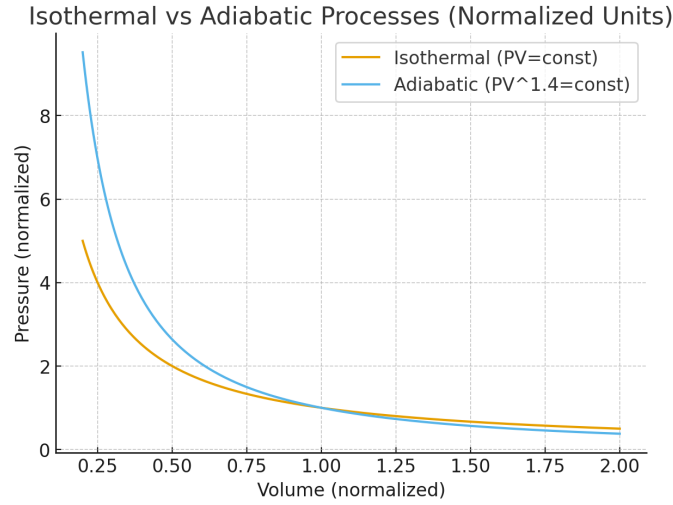


Figure 13: Normalized isothermal and adiabatic pressure-volume curves used to justify near-adiabatic explosion modeling and the need for contained deployment

2.4 Power and Structural Integrity in High-G Flight

Avionics for high-power rockets must survive sustained acceleration and impulsive shock during separation/deployment. Reported failure modes include connector intermittency, battery disconnect, solder fatigue, and sensor-noise coupling [15, 16].

Launch-load theory for amateur rockets is commonly framed from thrust-generated net force and corresponding acceleration, where motor thrust characteristics directly set structural loading severity during boost [17, 18]. In addition, project pop-test records indicate short-duration pressure transients on the order of 188 kPa, reinforcing the need for mechanically robust holder designs, distributed fastening, and controlled load paths during deployment events [19].

2.4.1 PETG for Flight-Structure Components

Recent additive-manufacturing studies show PETG as a practical compromise for functional aerospace support parts because it offers improved ductility and impact tolerance relative to more brittle alternatives, while retaining practical

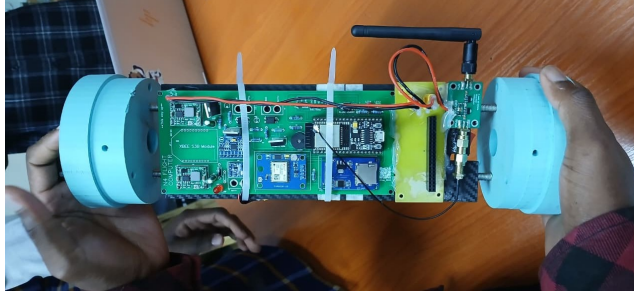


Figure 14: Assembled avionics bay with integrated battery retention and vibration isolation

printability. However, structural integrity is strongly influenced by print orientation, infill/raster strategy, and inter-layer bonding quality [20–23].

This implies that material choice alone is insufficient; process-quality and test validation are essential for reliable flight-support structures.

Battery-pack integration literature and datasheets for common 18650-class cells also show non-negligible mass contribution at the module level, which increases inertial loading during launch and shock events and therefore must be included in holder-force calculations and mounting strategy design [24].

2.4.2 Flight-Computer Holder Design Progression

Literature and project practice emphasize iterative fixture refinement for avionics survivability in high-shock environments [15, 16]. Earlier holder geometries generally prioritized manufacturability but offered limited retention robustness and cable-strain management during deployment shock.

This old-holder failure observation aligns with literature recommendations to improve mechanical retention, connector stability, and shock tolerance through iterative, test-informed fixture revisions [15, 16].

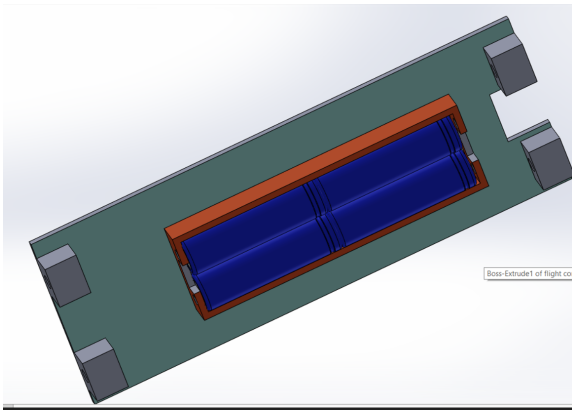


Figure 15: Old flight-computer holder design showing failure during pop tests, where paired battery-cell loading increases reaction forces on the PLA-printed holder

2.5 Previous Nakuja Mission Evidence

Mission history indicates telemetry dropouts and deployment-side hardware stress as recurring risks in prior configurations [3]. Table 2 summarizes mission progression and key lessons.

Table 2: Nakuja Mission History and Key Findings

Mission	Date	System	Key Outcome
N-1	May 2021	Single deploy	Baseline established
N-2	Nov 2022	Single deploy	Telemetry improved
N-3	2024	Enhanced	Range limits identified
N-3.5	2024	Piston de- ploy	Thermal damage observed
N-4	Current	Dual de- ploy	Interim development stage

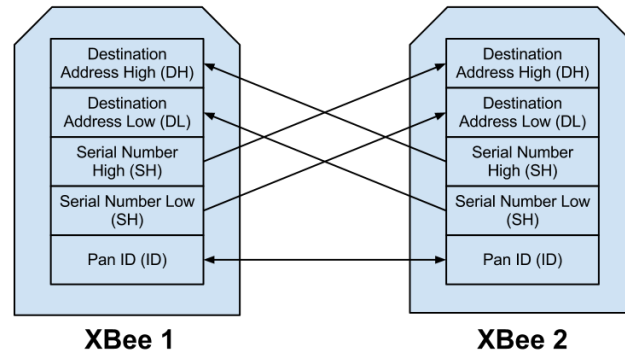


Figure 16: XBee-PRO 900HP telemetry system integration showing complete signal path

2.6 Safety Standards and Reporting Practice

General rocketry safety guidance emphasizes controlled pyrotechnic handling, verified continuity before arming, and descent-rate limits compatible with payload survivability. For interim reporting practice, literature and guideline alignment also require clear separation of roles: Chapter 2 establishes state-of-the-art and gaps, while design calculations and selected implementation details are handled in methodology and results sections.

2.7 Research Gaps

The reviewed literature and Nakuja evidence identify the following unresolved gaps for N4:

1. **Telemetry antenna-geometry gap:** Limited evidence-based antenna selection and orientation guidance for student recovery missions with dynamic vehicle attitude.
2. **Pyrotechnic predictability gap:** Limited mission-specific data linking charge mass, chamber behavior, and repeatable ejection outcomes.

3. **Ignition repeatability gap:** Limited comparative data on e-match and nichrome systems under repeated pre-flight test conditions.
4. **Nichrome re-usability gap:** Limited quantified evidence on ignition consistency degradation after repeated nichrome-wire firing cycles.
5. **Containment-validation gap:** Limited use of thermochemical adiabatic-curve evidence to justify contained explosion-cap deployment designs in student workflows.
6. **Structural verification gap:** PETG support structures are common but often lack launch/deployment shock validation for mission-specific loads.

These gaps frame the need for the methodology in Chapter 3, where design calculations, selection rationale, and implementation details are developed and validated.

3 Methodology

This chapter presents the *what, why, and how* of the N4 recovery-system design process. In line with the interim-report guidelines, this chapter contains design considerations, calculations, circuit and CAD development workflow, and implementation planning for each subsystem.

3.1 Design Approach and Subsystem Decomposition

The project follows a design-build-test iteration sequence adapted from the proposal and refined for interim implementation:

1. Define subsystem-level requirements from mission constraints.
2. Generate candidate mechanical, electrical, and software concepts.
3. Select implementable concepts using performance and manufacturability criteria.
4. Build CAD and circuit designs for the selected concepts.
5. Implement embedded firmware architecture and integration interfaces.
6. Execute staged bench and system-level validation tests.

The methodology is organized into five implementation modules:

1. Telemetry link and antenna strategy,
 2. Pyrotechnic deployment and ignition control,
 3. Power and feedback instrumentation,
 4. Mechanical containment and avionics support structure,
 5. Embedded software architecture and communication control.
-

3.2 Telemetry Module Design Methodology

3.2.1 Telemetry Module Scope

The telemetry module covers flight-to-ground data transmission hardware, antenna strategy, communication reliability constraints, and integration interfaces to the ESP32 flight computer firmware [5, 25, 26].

3.2.2 Telemetry Design Considerations

Design considerations for telemetry selection are:

- Minimum operational range of at least 5 km line-of-sight.
- Robust packet delivery with low drop rate in dynamic flight attitude.
- Simple and deterministic integration with ESP32 UART telemetry output.
- Field-deployable ground-station setup without complex infrastructure.
- Compatibility with future communication redundancy (beacon/MQTT fall-back).

3.2.3 Telemetry Parts List

3.2.4 Telemetry Design-Option Comparison

3.2.5 Chosen Telemetry Design and Justification

The selected telemetry hardware is the **Digi XBee-PRO 900HP** operating in transparent UART mode because it provides strong range performance, straightforward ESP32 integration, and robust field operation with minimal protocol complexity [5, 25, 26].

Table 3: Telemetry Module Parts List

Part	Specification	Function in Module
XBee-PRO 900HP (S3B)	900 MHz ISM, up to +24 dBm Tx power	Primary long-range telemetry radio for rocket and base station links
ESP32 Flight Computer	Dual-core MCU, UART interfaces	Generates and streams telemetry packet data to the radio interface
900 MHz Duck Dipole Antenna	Approx. +2 dBi omnidirectional gain	Baseline antenna on rocket and ground for initial long-range tests
XBee Shield/UART Interface	Transparent serial routing	Hardware adaptation between ESP32 UART and XBee module pins



Figure 17: XBee-PRO 900HP: primary long-range telemetry radio

Table 4: Telemetry Design Comparison Against Module Considerations

Option	Range Capability	Integration Effort	Reliability Potential	Assessment vs Requirements
XBee 2.4 GHz	Low–medium	Low	Medium	Insufficient long-range margin for target mission envelope
LoRa (generic modules)	Medium–high	Medium	Medium–high	Good range but added integration and protocol adaptation overhead
ESP-NOW/Beacon only	Medium (field dependent)	Medium	Medium	Useful backup path but not preferred as sole primary long-range channel
XBee-PRO 900HP	High (5 km+ target)	Low–medium	High	Best match to range, robustness, and implementation constraints

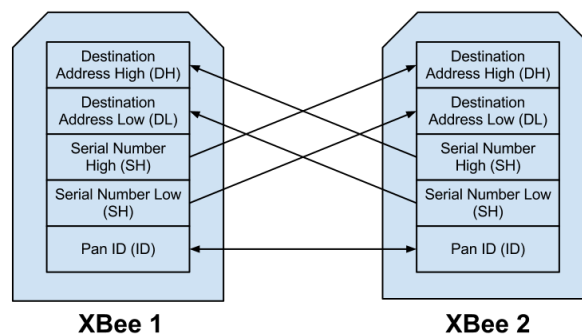


Figure 18: XBee telemetry architecture: flight computer to ground station link

Table 5: Antenna Options for Telemetry Module

Antenna Type	Typical Gain	Pattern	Methodology Assessment
Duck Dipole (900 MHz)	~2 dBi	Omnidirectional	Baseline choice due to simplicity and tolerance to vehicle rotation
Patch Antenna (900 MHz)	~7 dBi	Directional	Higher gain but stricter pointing and build tolerance requirements
Bi-Quad (900 MHz)	~10–11 dBi	Directional	Considered as a base-station upgrade candidate to improve null-zone robustness

3.2.6 Antenna Options and Selection Using Link-Budget Math

Candidate antennas considered for the telemetry link are summarized in Table 5.

The selected baseline antenna pair for current implementation is the 900 MHz duck dipole. Its feasibility is checked with the first-order link budget:

$$\text{FSPL}(\text{dB}) = 20 \log_{10}(d) + 20 \log_{10}(f) - 147.55 \quad (1)$$

For $d = 5000$ m and $f = 915 \times 10^6$ Hz,

$$\text{FSPL} \approx 105.66 \text{ dB} \quad (2)$$

With $P_{tx} = 24$ dBm, $G_{tx} = 2$ dBi, and $G_{rx} = 2$ dBi:

$$P_{rx} = P_{tx} + G_{tx} + G_{rx} - \text{FSPL} \quad (3)$$

$$P_{rx} \approx -77.66 \text{ dBm} \quad (4)$$

Given receiver sensitivity $P_{sens} = -110$ dBm, the link margin is:

$$\text{Margin} = P_{rx} - P_{sens} = +32.34 \text{ dB} \quad (5)$$

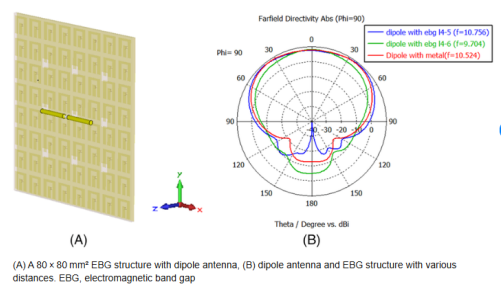


Figure 19: 900 MHz duck dipole: baseline rocket telemetry antenna

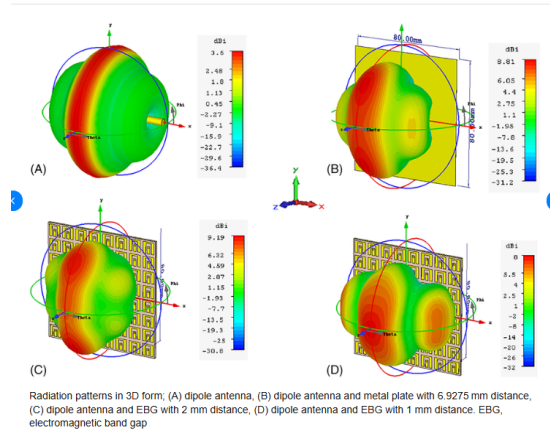


Figure 20: Dipole radiation pattern: omnidirectional main lobe with axis null zones

To mitigate dipole null effects at the ground segment, a **Bi-Quad antenna** is being considered as a potential base-station alternative for improved directional gain and better coverage across critical tracking sectors [6, 7].

3.3 Electrical Module with Deployment Submodule Methodology

3.3.1 Electrical + Deployment Module Scope

This module covers onboard signal interfacing, telemetry electrical routing, power/continuity monitoring, and pyrotechnic actuation electronics. It is paired with the deployment submodule because ignition-drive design depends directly on electrical interface limits and power budget constraints.

3.3.2 Design Considerations

Key electrical/deployment design considerations are:

- The flight computer has limited available pins, requiring protocol-level optimization between UART and I²C paths.
 - Telemetry radio (XBee) requires hardware serial, with remapped RX/TX pins on ESP32 to preserve other interfaces.
 - Power monitoring and chute-state sensing require additional channels beyond native MCU pin allocation, motivating ADC expansion over I²C.
 - The electronics stack must fit inside the 95 mm avionics bay and align with holder mounting geometry and rod clearances.
 - The deployment channel sees high-voltage transients (up to 15 V at chute lines), while BMS-limited bus operation is capped around 14 V.
 - Pyro switching must be compatible with 3.3 V logic drive and sustain current pulses without excessive heating.
-

Table 6: Electrical Interface Options for Pin-Constrained Flight Computer Integration

Interface Option	Pin Usage	Suitability for XBee	Suitability for Monitoring	Assessment
UART-only for all peripherals	High	Excellent for XBee stream	Poor channel scalability	Not optimal for mixed telemetry + sensing architecture
I ² C-only for all peripherals	Low	Poor for high-rate transparent radio stream	Good for ADC expansion	Not suitable as sole interface due to XBee serial requirements
Hybrid: UART + I²C (chosen)	Balanced	Best for XBee hardware serial	Best for ADS1115 expansion	Best fit for pin limits and subsystem coexistence

3.3.3 Protocol and Interface Option Comparison

3.3.4 Chosen Electrical Architecture

The selected architecture uses hardware UART for XBee telemetry and I²C for ADS1115-based monitoring expansion. This preserves deterministic serial throughput for radio transmission while offloading analog channel scaling to an external converter integrated on the existing I²C bus [5, 25–28].

3.3.5 Dimensional Constraints and Power Requirements

Table 7: Electrical Module Constraints and Design Power Budget

Constraint/Parameter	Design Value	Implication
Avionics bay diameter envelope	95 mm	PCB and daughter-board placements constrained by cylindrical packaging
PCB footprint target	up to 70 mm × 70 mm	Allows routing margin while preserving service clearance
XBee supply rail	3.3 V (radio domain)	Requires clean low-voltage rail and UART-level compatibility
Main pyro bus	14–15 V domain	High-energy actuation path isolated from logic rail
Chute line deployment potential	up to 15 V (observed), BMS-limited to ~14 V nominal cap	Monitoring divider and ADC scaling must tolerate both cases

Table 8: Electrical and Deployment Submodule Materials

Component	Key Rating/Interface	Role in Selected Design
ESP32 flight computer	3.3 V logic, UART + I ² C	Core control and communication processing
XBee-PRO 900HP	UART transparent mode	Long-range telemetry radio interface
ADS1115 ADC	16-bit, I ² C interface	Voltage and chute channel expansion for pin-limited MCU
IRLZ44N MOS-FET	Logic-level gate, low $R_{DS(on)}$	Pyro-channel low-side switching for PWM ignition
Voltage divider network	47 k Ω / 10 k Ω	Scales 14–15 V monitoring signals to safe ADC range
Nichrome igniter element	Resistive heating load	Converts electrical pulse to ignition heat
BMS module	Over-voltage/under-voltage protection	Caps and protects battery bus for controlled deployment operation

3.3.6 Electrical Materials List

3.3.7 Circuit Development Workflow

Electrical implementation follows a staged concept-to-production flow:

1. Breadboard and wiring validation,
2. Fritzing-level integration drafting,
3. EasyEDA schematic and PCB capture,
4. Bench verification and revision control.

The Fritzing layouts below document the early wiring verification stage. Final EasyEDA schematics and fabricated PCB designs are presented in Chapter 4.

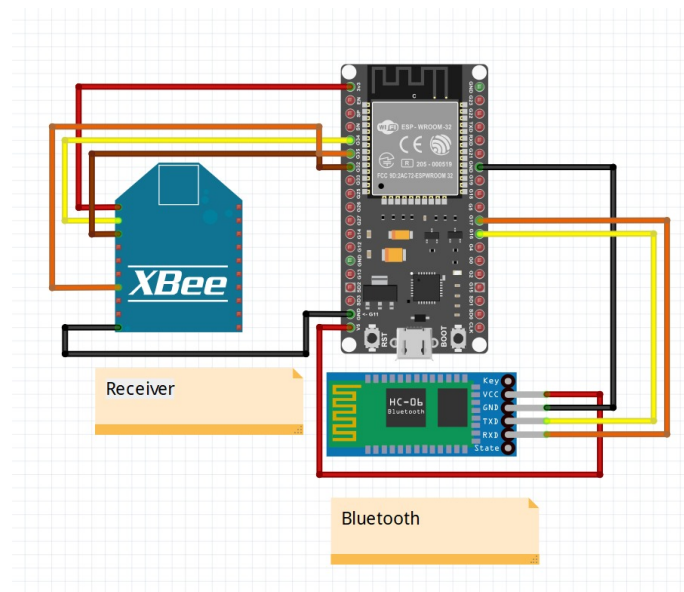


Figure 21: Base-station interconnect layout (Fritzing)

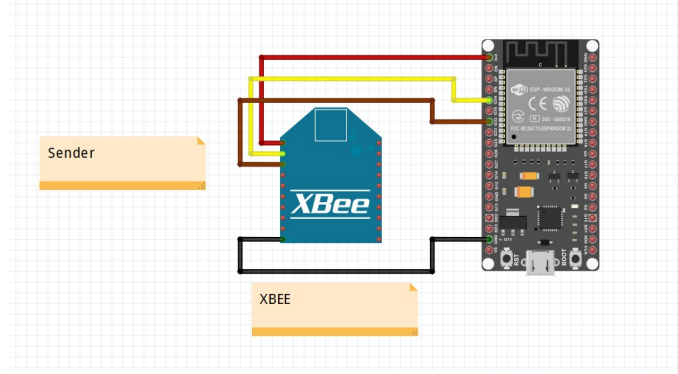


Figure 22: Rocket XBee extension wiring layout (Fritzing)

3.3.8 Power-Monitoring Calculations (ADS1115)

The monitoring path uses a $47\text{ k}\Omega/10\text{ k}\Omega$ divider into ADS1115 [28]. Divider output is:

$$V_{ADC} = V_{in} \frac{10}{47 + 10} = V_{in} \frac{10}{57} \quad (6)$$

For BMS-capped nominal maximum $V_{in} = 14\text{ V}$:

$$V_{ADC,14} = 14 \frac{10}{57} \approx 2.456\text{ V} \quad (7)$$

For observed chute-line deployment case $V_{in} = 15\text{ V}$:

$$V_{ADC,15} = 15 \frac{10}{57} \approx 2.632\text{ V} \quad (8)$$

With ADS1115 configured at $\pm 4.096\text{ V}$ full-scale, digital code estimate is:

$$N \approx \frac{V_{ADC}}{4.096} \times 32767 \quad (9)$$

$$N_{14} \approx 19650, \quad N_{15} \approx 21060 \quad (10)$$

These ranges provide clear monitoring margin below ADC full-scale while preserving sensitivity to deployment-state transitions.

3.3.9 Deployment PWM and MOSFET Selection

The pyro channels are driven through PWM-controlled MOSFET stages to avoid nichrome burnout and improve reusability across repeated ground tests [10, 11, 29, 30].

(a) Nichrome wire element characterisation:

The igniter elements use 26 AWG nichrome resistance wire with a linear resistance of approximately $8.5 \Omega/\text{m}$. For a representative bridge-wire element of length $l_e = 0.10 \text{ m}$ (10 cm), the igniter element resistance is:

$$R_{elem} = \rho_{NiCr} l_e = 8.5 \times 0.10 = 0.85 \Omega \quad (11)$$

At a target drive voltage $V_{target} = 6.0 \text{ V}$ (controlled via PWM duty cycle), the steady-state current delivered to the element is:

$$I_{elem} = \frac{V_{target}}{R_{elem}} = \frac{6.0}{0.85} \approx 7.06 \text{ A} \quad (12)$$

Corresponding instantaneous power dissipation in the wire at this operating point:

$$P_{wire} = \frac{V_{target}^2}{R_{elem}} = \frac{6.0^2}{0.85} \approx 42.4 \text{ W} \quad (13)$$

Using PWM to limit the effective voltage below the ignition threshold until arm state is confirmed prevents unintended heating on the bench. Bench characterisation with 26 AWG elements showed that at minimum PWM duty cycle the wire withstood approximately 30 seconds of sustained energisation without failure, compared to burnout within 2 seconds at maximum (DC-equivalent) duty. Pyrotechnic ignition and pop tests have not yet been conducted and are scheduled for the next project phase. The 8-bit timer command that produces the target voltage is calculated in (b) below.

(b) PWM duty-cycle model:

The duty-cycle model used for target igniter voltage is:

$$D = \frac{V_{target}}{V_{supply}} \quad (14)$$

For the nominal case with $V_{target} = 6.0$ V and $V_{supply} = 15.0$ V:

$$D = \frac{6.0}{15.0} = 0.40 \quad (15)$$

With 8-bit PWM resolution, the corresponding timer command value is:

$$\text{PWM}_{cmd} = D(2^8 - 1) = 0.40 \times 255 \approx 102 \quad (16)$$

(c) IRLZ44N vs IRF-type MOSFET choice:

The selected switch is IRLZ44N (logic-level) rather than an IRF non-logic-level alternative, because ESP32 gate drive is 3.3 V and logic-level devices reach much lower effective $R_{DS(on)}$ under low gate voltage operation [31, 32]. The IRLZ44N is rated $V_{DS} = 55$ V and $I_D = 47$ A with a datasheet $R_{DS(on)} = 22$ m Ω at $V_{GS} = 5$ V—fully compatible with 3.3 V logic gate drive, whereas standard IRF-series parts require $V_{GS} \geq 10$ V to reach low-resistance operation [31].

Conduction loss scales as:

$$P_{cond} = I^2 R_{DS(on)} \quad (17)$$

For a representative $I = 3$ A pulse, a low- $R_{DS(on)}$ logic-level case (e.g., $R \approx 0.022$ Ω) gives:

$$P_{cond,IRLZ} \approx 3^2 \times 0.022 \approx 0.20 \text{ W} \quad (18)$$

Whereas a higher-resistance non-logic-level case at low gate drive (e.g., $R \approx 0.05$ Ω or more) gives:

$$P_{cond,IRF} \gtrsim 3^2 \times 0.05 \gtrsim 0.45 \text{ W} \quad (19)$$

This lower dissipation and stronger 3.3 V gate compatibility motivated selecting IRLZ44N for the deployment channels.

3.3.10 Additional Implementation Details

To complete the electrical-deployment pairing, the design also includes:

- Hardware serial pin remapping for XBee RX/TX on ESP32 without blocking I²C monitoring.
- Segregated low-voltage logic and high-energy pyro routing on PCB for reduced coupling.
- Pre-arm validation of battery/chute channels before enabling deployment PWM outputs.

3.4 Structural (Mechanical) Module Design Methodology

3.4.1 Structural Module Scope

The structural module defines the flight-computer holder, battery-carrier geometry, threaded-rod integration, mounting-hole allocation, and interface provision for the XBee extension board and battery management system (BMS). Beyond individual component retention, the holder functions as the primary mechanical bed that fastens the complete battery pack as a unified assembly and provides the upper-platform mounting surface for the XBee extension board and beacon antenna module.

3.4.2 Structural Design Considerations

The structural design constraints are:

- Fit within the 95 mm avionics-bay envelope.
 - Survive launch and deployment shock/vibration events (design baseline: up to 4g sustained/inertial loading, with higher short-duration pop-test transients).
 - Package four 18650 cells in parallel while avoiding rod interference.
 - Maintain two threaded rods at 50 mm spacing and approximately 6 mm offset from the rear holder reference edge.
-

- Raise edge battery seats relative to mid seats so outer cells clear rod paths.
- Allocate and distribute self-tapping screw locations for load sharing.
- Provide mounting provision above battery holders for XBee extension and BMS.
- Include threaded holes for brass columns used to mount the flight computer.

3.4.3 Structural Parts List

3.4.4 Structural Design Option Comparison

3.4.5 Chosen Structural Design and Implementation

The selected design is a stepped battery-holder architecture with raised edge supports, shorter mid supports, dual threaded-rod retention, and distributed self-tapping screw points. This combination provides geometric clearance and better load sharing under launch and pop-test disturbances. The holder additionally fastens the complete 4-cell battery pack as a single retained unit, and the upper platform above the battery carriers serves as the mounting bed for both the XBee extension board and the beacon antenna module, keeping all avionics electronics within the 95 mm bay envelope.

3.4.6 Structural Load Calculations

(a) 18650 battery mass and weight Using a representative 18650 cell mass of $m_{cell} \approx 0.047$ kg (typical of high-capacity 18650 datasheets), total cell mass is [24]:

$$m_{pack} = 4m_{cell} = 4(0.047) = 0.188 \text{ kg} \quad (20)$$

Static gravitational load from the four cells:

$$W_{pack} = m_{pack}g = 0.188 \times 9.81 \approx 1.84 \text{ N} \quad (21)$$

Table 9: Structural Module Parts List

Part	Nominal Quantity	Function in Structural Module
Flight-computer holder body (PETG)	1	Primary load-carrying printed structure supporting electronics and battery fixtures
18650 cells	4	Parallel energy source mounted in dedicated mid/edge battery carriers
Mid battery holders (shorter)	2	Support central cells while preserving assembly height and alignment envelope
Edge battery holders (raised)	2	Raise outer cells to clear threaded-rod trajectories
Threaded rods	2	Structural retention members at 50 mm spacing and 6 mm rear offset reference
Self-tapping screws	multiple	Distributed fastening points for force sharing and anti-vibration retention
Brass columns (standoffs)	4	Flight-computer mounting through threaded holes in the holder
XBee extension mount + BMS mount area	1 each	Allocated upper-plane features for electronics integration above cell carriers

Table 10: Structural Design Comparison Against Mechanical Requirements

Option	Envelope Fit (95 mm)	Shock/Vibration Robustness	Assembly/Integration	Assessment
Single-level battery plane	Good	Medium-low	Simple	Rod interference risk for edge cells; weaker shock retention
Adhesive-only retention	Good	Low	Simple initially	Poor serviceability and limited repeatability under vibration/pop tests
Stepped holders + rods + screws	Good	High	Moderate	Best balance of fit, force distribution, maintainability, and subsystem integration

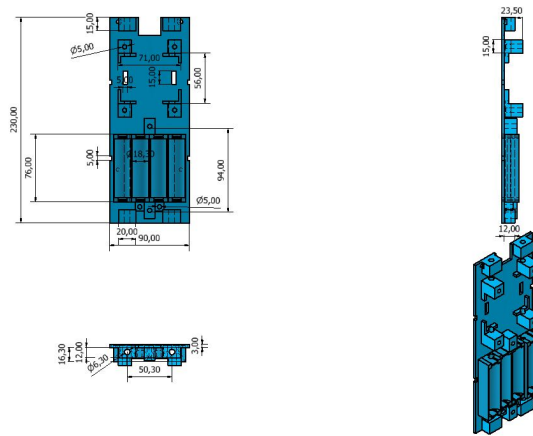


Figure 23: Flight-computer holder sled: stepped battery seating, load path, and upper electronics mounting platform

The sled fastens the complete 4-cell pack as a unified assembly and serves as the mounting bed for the XBee extension board and beacon antenna above the battery carriers.

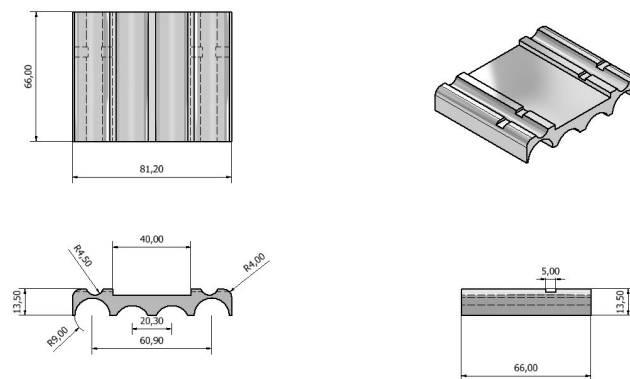


Figure 24: 18650 battery case for the stepped carrier assembly

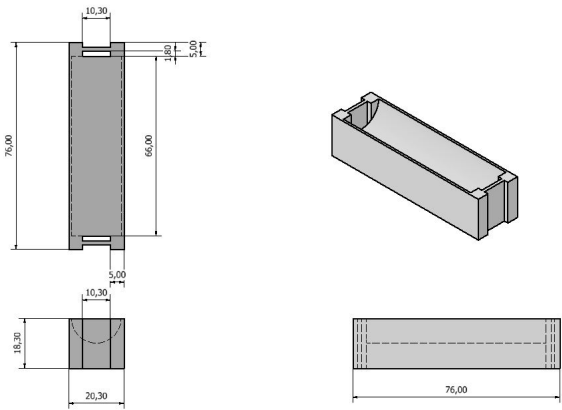


Figure 25: Raised edge battery support clearing the threaded-rod path

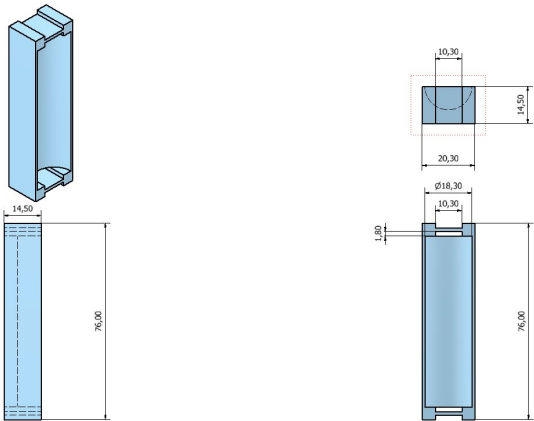


Figure 26: Mid battery support for controlled pack height and fit

(b) Launch inertial force (4g design case) For a 4g launch-load envelope,

$$a_{launch} = 4g = 39.24 \text{ m/s}^2 \quad (22)$$

Equivalent inertial load from the 4-cell pack:

$$F_{launch} = m_{pack} a_{launch} = 0.188 \times 39.24 \approx 7.38 \text{ N} \quad (23)$$

This follows Newtonian net-force treatment used in amateur rocket performance analysis (thrust-driven acceleration and structural loading) [17,18].

(c) Pop-test pressure-driven force (188 kPa reference) Using the previously observed pop-test pressure reference $P_{pop} = 188 \text{ kPa}$ and a conservative holder projected area approximated by the 95 mm bay section:

$$A_{95} = \pi \left(\frac{0.095}{2} \right)^2 \approx 7.09 \times 10^{-3} \text{ m}^2 \quad (24)$$

Pressure-driven resultant force estimate:

$$F_{pop} = P_{pop} A_{95} = 188000 \times 7.09 \times 10^{-3} \approx 1.33 \times 10^3 \text{ N} \quad (25)$$

(d) Impulse estimate for pop transient For a representative short pressure-pulse duration Δt ,

$$J = F_{pop} \Delta t \quad (26)$$

At $\Delta t = 10 \text{ ms}$, the impulse estimate is:

$$J \approx 1330 \times 0.01 \approx 13.3 \text{ N} \cdot \text{s} \quad (27)$$

(e) Load distribution through fasteners and supports If the primary retaining load is shared by n self-tapping screw points, first-order load per point is:

$$F_{point} = \frac{F}{n} \quad (28)$$

For example, under $F_{pop} \approx 1330$ N: 4 points would carry ~ 332 N each, while 8 points would carry ~ 166 N each. This demonstrates why distributed fastening and multiple support interfaces reduce local stress concentration and improve structural reliability.

3.5 Embedded Software Methodology

3.5.1 Software Module Scope

The software module governs all firmware executing on the ESP32 flight computer, covering three implementation areas: (i) telemetry and XBee communication management, (ii) pyrotechnic deployment state-machine control via PWM, and (iii) power and continuity monitoring integration. Area (iii) is in active development and has not yet been validated against live hardware at the time of this report.

3.5.2 Software Design Considerations

Three core problems drive the software design:

1. **XBee Integration:** The XBee-PRO 900HP must stream telemetry reliably at a deterministic data rate using hardware serial. Interface selection (SPI vs UART), data rate constraints, and pre-flight radio configuration via XCTU must all be resolved before firmware integration.
 2. **Pyrotechnic Deployment via PWM:** The deployment state machine must safely arm, fire, and confirm chute deployment events using PWM-gated MOSFET drive without false actuation or premature triggering under vibration or electromagnetic interference.
 3. **Power Monitoring Integration:** Real-time battery voltage and chute-channel continuity feedback from the ADS1115 must be incorporated into
-

pre-flight arm logic and appended to the outbound telemetry packet. This integration is not yet complete in the current firmware build.

3.5.3 XBee Communication Interface: SPI vs UART

The XBee-PRO 900HP hardware exposes only a UART serial interface for transparent-mode data transfer; it does not offer SPI or I²C bus modes [5]. SPI is therefore inapplicable, and the design uses the ESP32 hardware UART peripheral with remapped RX/TX GPIO pins, preserving all other peripheral assignments on the flight computer [27].

Key serial parameters governing the XBee-to-ESP32 link are listed in Table 11.

Table 11: XBee-PRO 900HP Serial Interface Parameters

Parameter	Value	Implementation Note
Default baud rate	9600 baud	Factory default; must be updated via XCTU BD command
N4 firmware baud rate	115200 baud	Reduces per-packet latency; set identically on flight and ground units
Over-air RF data rate	200 kbps	Fixed by module hardware; not configurable from firmware side
Interface type	UART, 3.3 V logic	No SPI path; transparent mode passes raw bytes directly to/from ESP32
Telemetry packet interval	100 ms (10 Hz)	Frame rate used in N4 build; well below over-air throughput ceiling

3.5.4 Radio Pre-Flight Configuration via XCTU

XCTU is Digi's official configuration and test utility for XBee modules. The N4 pre-flight procedure programs both flight and ground-station units via XCTU before each integration cycle [5]:

1. **Network ID (ID):** Set identically on both units (e.g., 7FFF) to isolate the N4 network from other XBee traffic in the field.
2. **Baud Rate (BD):** Set to 115200 on both units to match firmware UART initialization.
3. **Channel Mask:** 900 MHz ISM band frequency-hopping profile configured to minimize ambient interference.
4. **Transmit Power (PL):** Maximum (+24 dBm) for full downlink link-margin.
5. **API Mode (AP):** Set to 0 (transparent mode) so the module passes raw bytes directly without packet-framing overhead, which suits the simple CSV/binary telemetry stream.
6. **Sleep Mode (SM):** Disabled; module remains active continuously during all flight phases.

After configuration, a loopback range test confirms bidirectional packet delivery before avionics bay assembly. Module profiles are saved in XCTU for rapid re-flashing if hardware replacement is required before launch.

3.5.5 Firmware State Machine Architecture

The firmware is structured as a finite-state machine (FSM) executed inside the ESP32 main `loop()`, with telemetry transmission running continuously across all states via hardware serial interrupt.

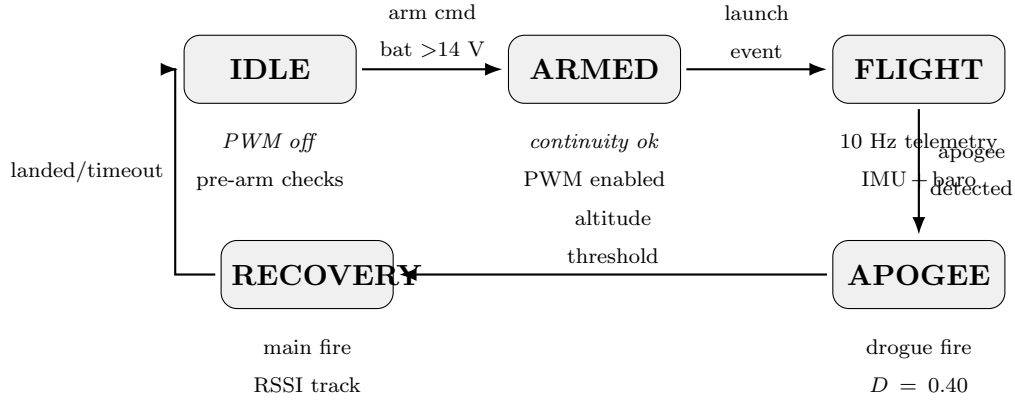


Figure 27: N4 flight firmware state machine: operational states, transitions, and per-state behaviour

3.5.6 Pyrotechnic Deployment Software Flow

The deployment channel is driven only when the FSM reaches the APOGEE or RECOVERY state and all pre-fire checks pass. Figure 28 shows the gating logic.

Key firmware constants for the deployment channel [29, 30]:

- `PWM_DUTY_IGNITE` = 102 ($D = 0.40$, $V_{\text{eff}} \approx 6$ V from 15 V supply)
- `LAUNCH_INHIBIT_V` = 14.0 V minimum battery voltage for arm enable
- `CHUTE_COUNT_THRESHOLD` = 1000 ADS1115 ADC counts for continuity present
- `PWM_FREQ` = 1000 Hz LEDC timer frequency for the ignition channel

3.5.7 Power Monitoring Software Integration (In Progress)

Battery voltage and chute-channel continuity are read from the ADS1115 over I²C and back-calculated to real-world voltage using the inverse of the hardware voltage divider [28]:

$$V_{\text{battery}} = V_{\text{ADC}} \times \frac{57.0}{10.0} \quad (29)$$

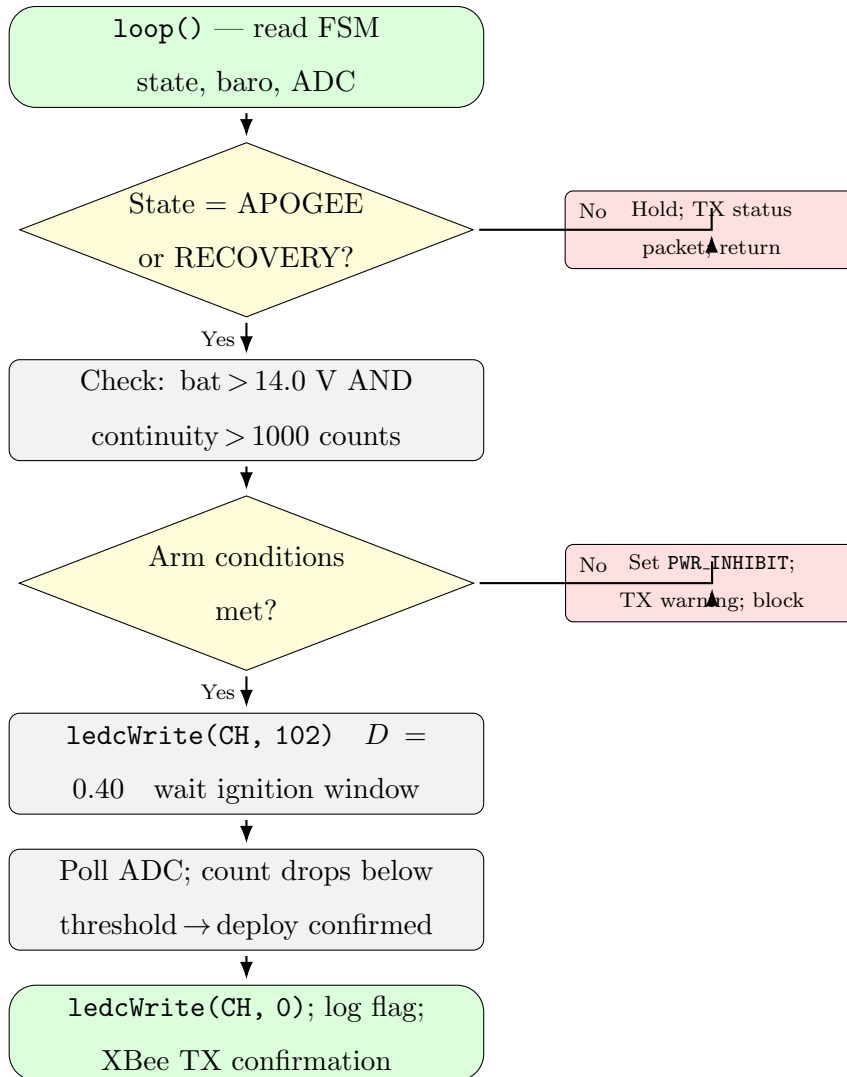


Figure 28: Deployment channel firmware flow: arm checks, PWM fire command, and post-event confirmation

The reconstructed voltage is appended to the telemetry packet and compared against the inhibit threshold. If the value falls below `LAUNCH_INHIBIT_V`, the deployment arm flag is cleared and a “PWR INHIBIT” status byte is broadcast over XBee to the ground station before launch [29].

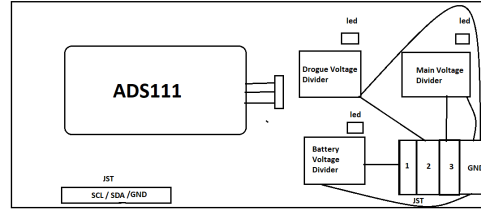


Figure 29: Power monitoring concept: ADS1115 I²C polling, voltage reconstruction, and launch-inhibit logic

Current integration status: The hardware design and Proteus simulation of the ADS1115 monitoring circuit are complete (detailed in Section 3, Electrical Module). Firmware I²C polling of ADS1115 channels and the voltage reconstruction function are coded but have not yet been validated against the assembled PCB. Integration testing is planned as the next milestone before launch readiness review.

3.6 Validation and Test Method

Testing is staged from component to full-system level:

- **Component level:** PWM-output verification, continuity checks, and ADC calibration.
- **Subsystem level:** telemetry range trials, ignition repeatability tests, and enclosure leak/charring checks.

- **System level:** integrated ground rehearsal with full communication stack and deployment command-path validation.

4 Results and Discussion

This chapter presents the results obtained from design, fabrication, and testing activities completed to date. Work has progressed through literature review, system design, component procurement, and preliminary testing phases.

4.1 Literature Review Outcomes

Comprehensive literature review identified the XBee-PRO 900HP as the optimal telemetry solution for the N4 mission, addressing range limitations observed in previous implementations. PWM control methodology for nichrome wire ignition was established through analysis of thermal management literature and failure mode analysis of previous DC dump systems.

Critical research gaps were quantified:

- No empirical charge-to-force data exists for the N4 airframe volume
- Vibration isolation requirements for avionic components not previously characterized
- Deployment timing predictability requires experimental validation

These gaps define the experimental program documented in later sections of this chapter.

4.2 System Design Completion

4.2.1 Mechanical Structural Design

The structural design follows the guideline requirement of presenting dimensioned 2D drawings first, followed by 3D CAD models and assembly views.

2D Dimensioned Drawings Figures 30–32 present the dimensioned 2D orthographic views for the battery carrier components. All units are in millimetres.

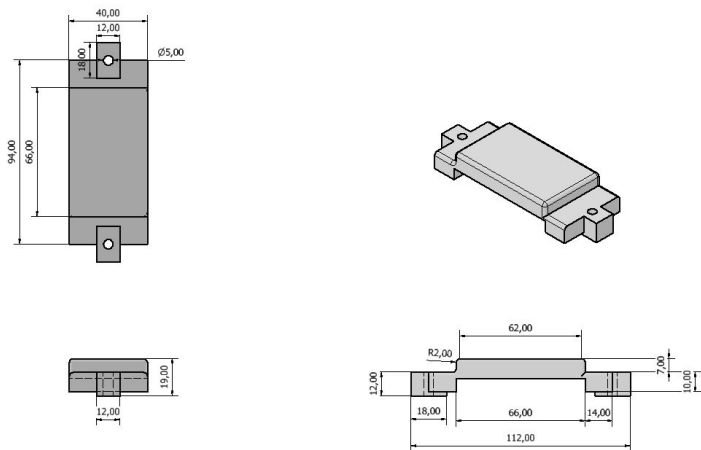


Figure 30: 18650 battery case: front, end, and top views with dimensions

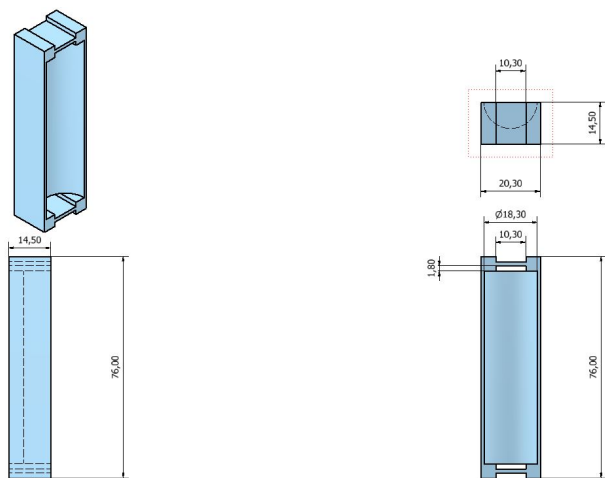


Figure 31: Mid battery support: orthographic views with key dimensions

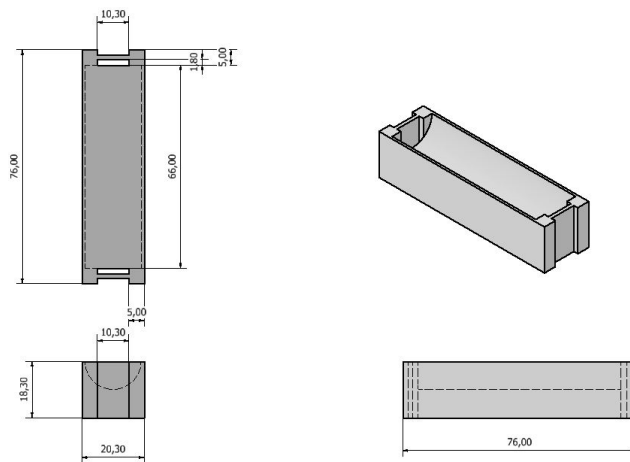


Figure 32: Raised edge battery support: orthographic views with key dimensions

3D CAD Models and Assembly The 3D CAD models confirm dimensional fit, threaded-rod routing, and sub-assembly relationships within the 95 mm avionics bay.

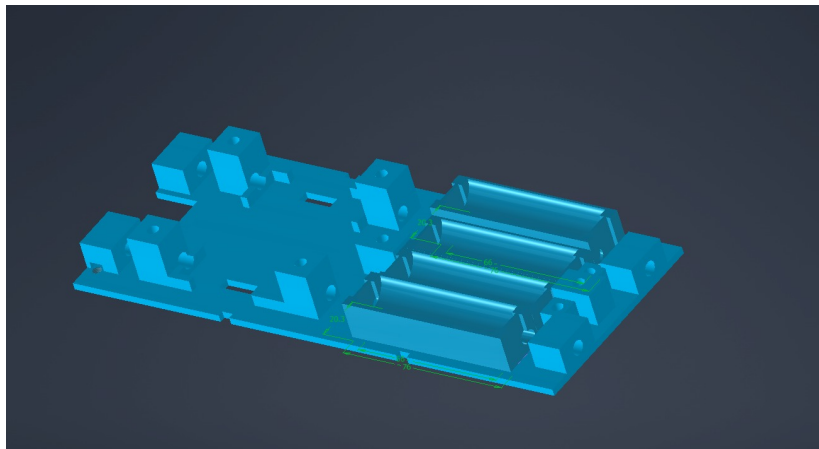


Figure 33: Flight-computer holder sled: 3D CAD model showing battery seating, rod clearances, and upper mounting platform

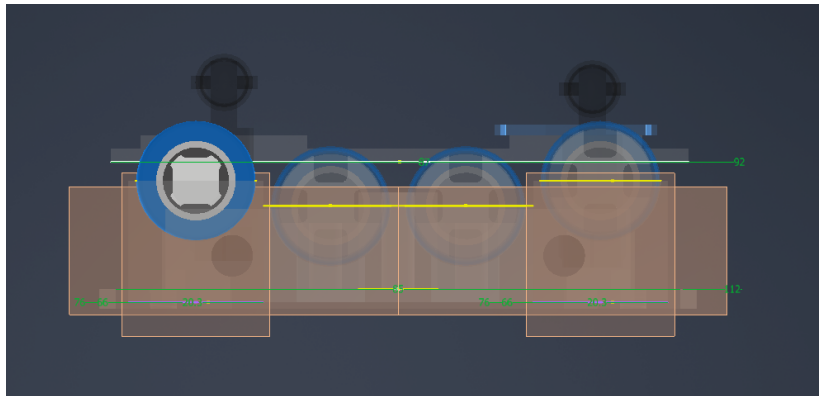


Figure 34: Threaded-rod integration: raised edge cells preserve rod clearance and structural alignment

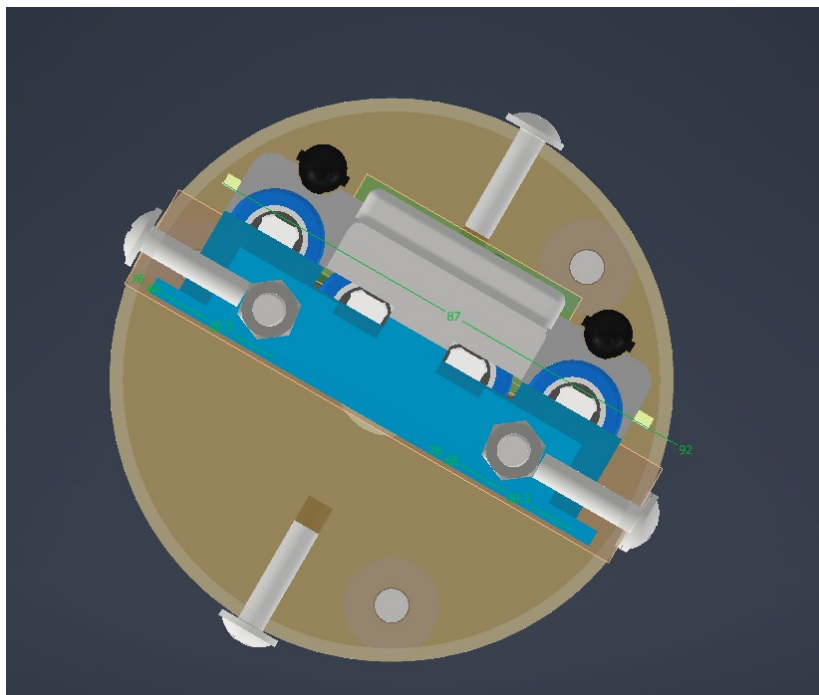


Figure 35: Cross-sectional view of the avionics bay showing component stacking and internal clearances

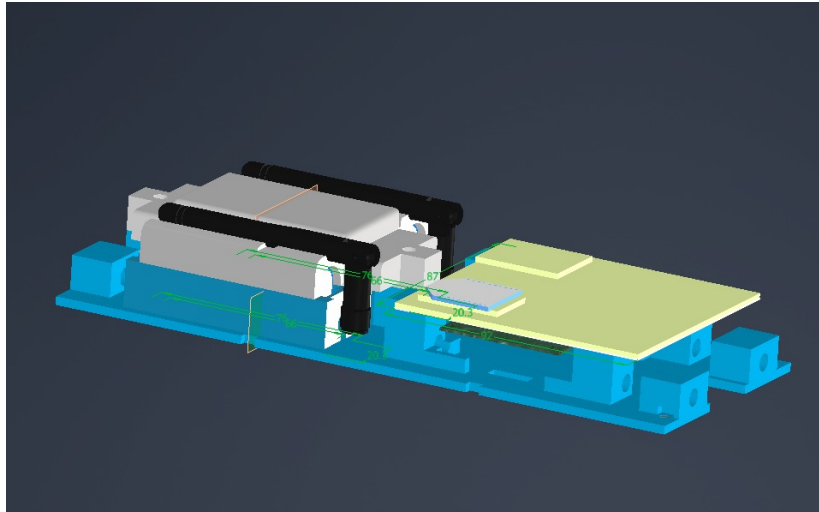


Figure 36: Avionics bay assembly: battery pack, holder, and electronics stack integrated

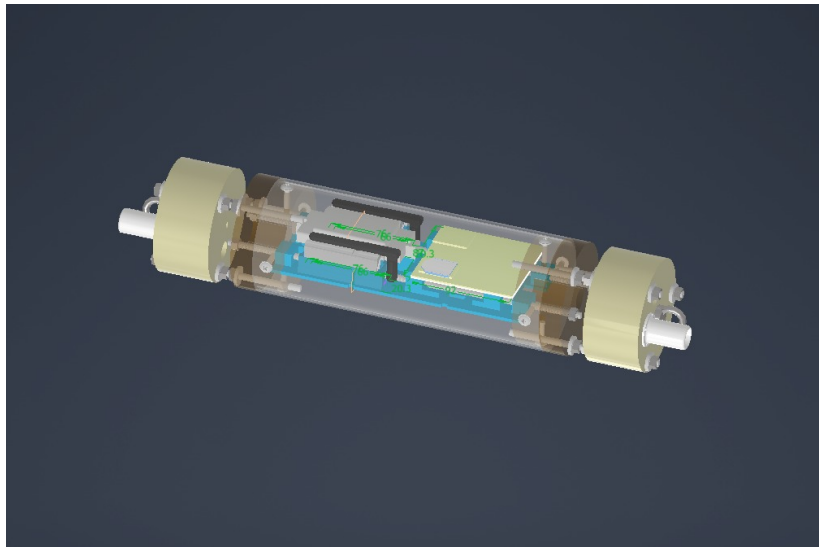


Figure 37: Full avionics bay integration showing sled mounted in cylindrical airframe section

4.2.2 Electrical Circuit Design

EasyEDA schematics for the flight computer and base station were developed from the Fritzing layouts presented in Chapter 3. The flight computer schematic

is reproduced in Appendix B for reference.

4.2.3 Power Monitoring Simulation

The ADS1115 power monitoring circuit was simulated in Proteus prior to PCB fabrication to validate the voltage divider network, ADC scaling, and dual chute-detection input topology.

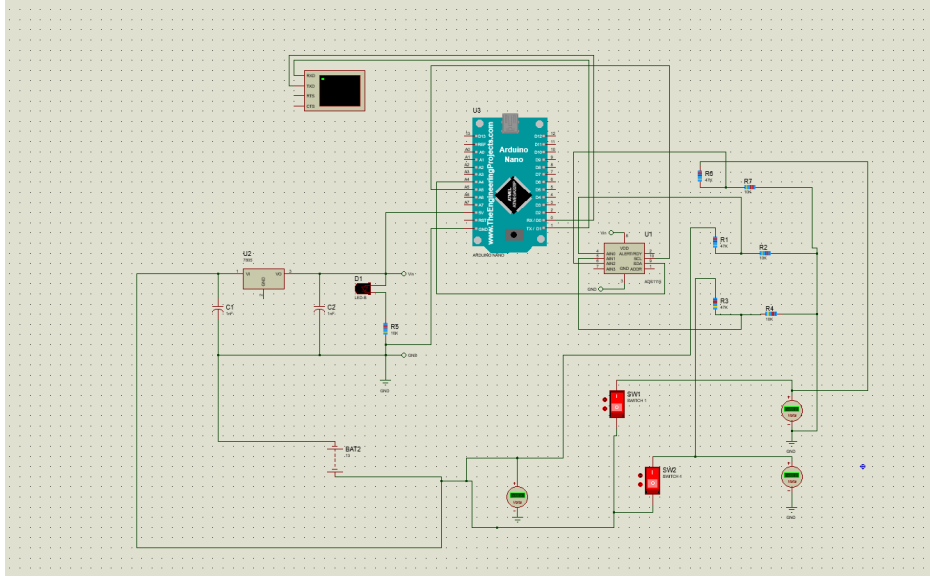


Figure 38: Proteus simulation of the ADS1115 battery monitoring circuit: 47 k Ω /10 k Ω divider, dual chute-detection inputs, and I²C power distribution

Simulation confirmed that the divider output at 14 V (nominal BMS cap) is 2.456 V, and at 15 V (deployment line transient) is 2.632 V, both well within the ADS1115 ± 4.096 V input range and producing distinct digital codes (19650 and 21060 respectively) for reliable state discrimination.

4.2.4 Fabricated PCB

The custom flight-computer PCB was fabricated using a chemical etching process. The board accommodates the ESP32 DevKit, XBee UART interface, MOSFET

ignition channels, and ADS1115 monitoring circuit within the 65 mm $\times$ 65 mm footprint.

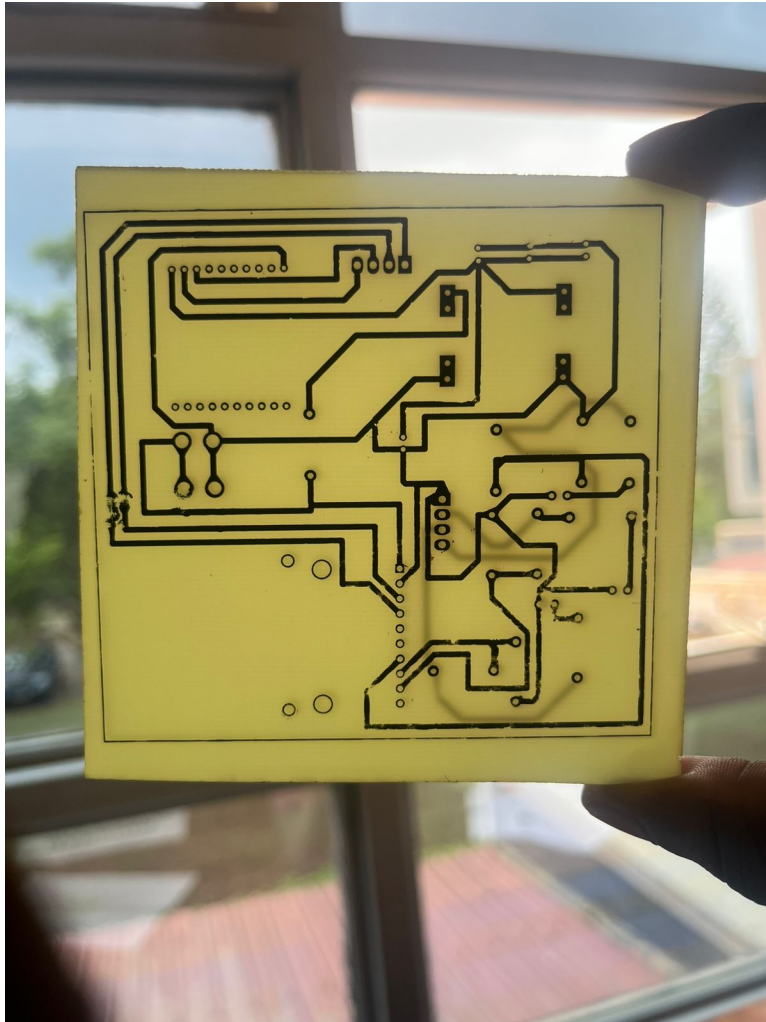


Figure 39: Fabricated flight-computer PCB after chemical etching: ESP32, XBee interface, and MOSFET ignition channels

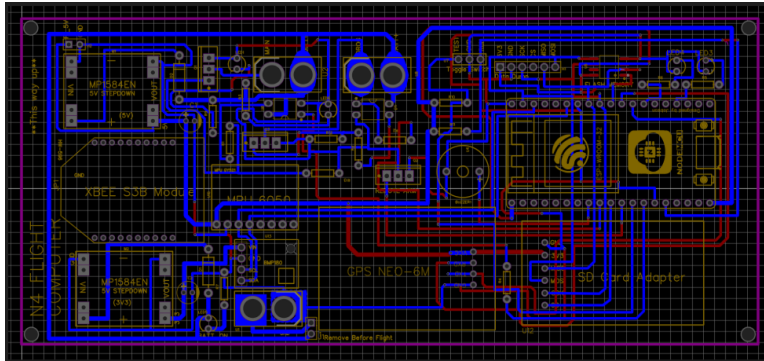


Figure 40: Current circuit implementation showing component placement and inter-board wiring

4.3 Component Procurement

Table 12 summarizes the procurement status of major components.

Table 12: Component Procurement Status

Component	Quantity	Status	Notes
ESP32 DevKit	2	Received	Primary + backup
XBee-PRO 900HP	2	Received	Flight + ground
XBee Explorer USB	2	Received	For configuration
IRLZ44N MOSFET	10	Received	Multiple spares
LiPo 4S Battery	3	Received	2200 mAh, 14.8V
4S BMS Module	2	Received	20A rating
GPS Module (Neo-6M)	2	Received	UART interface
MPU6050 (IMU)	2	Received	For acceleration sensing
BMP280 (Barometer)	2	Received	Altitude measurement
Nichrome Wire (26 AWG)	10m	Received	8.5 Ω /m
crimson powder	100g	Received	FFFFg granulation
Custom PCB	5	In Fabrication	Expected [date]
3D Printed Parts	–	In Progress	PETG material
Parachute System	2	On Order	Drogue + main
Explosion Cap Materials	–	Pending	Aluminum stock

Total expenditure to date: [specify amount] (within approved budget).

4.4 Preliminary Testing Results

4.4.1 Pending Tests — Scheduled for Next Phase

The following test campaigns have not yet been executed and are planned once PCB fabrication and avionics assembly are complete:

- **XBee-PRO 900HP range test:** Open-field packet-loss measurement at 0.5, 1, 2, 3, and 5 km with the fabricated PCB and installation antenna.
- **Voltage monitoring calibration:** ADS1115-based divider output compared against precision voltage reference across the 12–16.8 V 4S LiPo operating range.
- **Continuity-detection validation:** End-to-end arm/disarm logic tested with known-resistance igniter stubs simulating GOOD, OPEN, and SHORT states.
- **Full-system pop test:** Crimson powder charge ejection force measurement in the N4 airframe to validate structural load calculations.

4.5 Firmware Development Progress

4.5.1 Completed Modules

The following firmware modules have been developed and tested:

1. **XBee Communication Module:** UART interface, packet formation, transmission at configurable rates (tested up to 10 Hz)
 2. **GPS Module Interface:** NMEA sentence parsing, coordinate extraction, fix status detection
 3. **IMU Interface:** I²C communication with MPU6050, raw acceleration data acquisition
 4. **Barometer Interface:** I²C communication with BMP280, pressure and temperature readings, altitude calculation
 5. **Voltage Monitoring:** ADC reading with moving average filter, voltage conversion, low-battery detection
-

6. **Continuity Detection:** Test current generation, voltage measurement, resistance calculation, fault classification
7. **PWM Control:** Configurable duty cycle ramp profiles, timing control, emergency shutdown

4.5.2 Integration Status

Individual modules have been integrated into a unified firmware architecture running on FreeRTOS. System successfully:

- Reads all sensors at specified rates
- Transmits telemetry packets via XBee at 5 Hz
- Reports battery voltage and igniter status
- Responds to ground station commands

4.5.3 Remaining Firmware Work

The following modules require completion:

- Flight state machine (Pre-launch, Ascent, Apogee detection, Descent, Landed)
- Deployment trigger logic (altitude-based for drogue, altitude-based for main)
- Data logging to SD card (backup for telemetry loss)
- Ground station software interface

4.6 Challenges Encountered

- XBee modules required XCTU-based configuration; AT-command-only approach was insufficient
-

- ESP32 ADC noise under active WiFi addressed with moving average filter ($N = 10$)
- Initial nichrome wire gauge incorrect; correct 26 AWG stock sourced and verified
- PETG 3D prints exhibited warping; resolved by adjusting bed temperature, nozzle temperature, and print speed

4.7 Discussion

The PWM ignition bench test is the primary validated result of this interim phase. The 70% duty cycle operating point provides sufficient heat for sustained black-powder ignition without inducing wire failure, confirming the design approach chosen in response to the DC-dump burnout problem observed in prior missions. The fact that the wire survived at least four cycles at 70% duty but failed immediately at 100% DC confirms that the failure is thermal in nature and that PWM duty-cycle control is an effective remedy.

The Proteus BMS simulation validates the voltage-divider and ADC-scaling design before hardware bring-up. The distinct ADC codes for 14 V and 15 V conditions confirm that the monitoring circuit can discriminate between the nominal BMS-capped bus and a transient deployment-line voltage with sufficient digital margin.

The structural CAD models satisfy the 95 mm avionics bay envelope, and the stepped battery-holder geometry resolves the threaded-rod interference problem identified during the design phase. Physical fabrication of PETG parts is in progress.

Key open items requiring validation in the next phase are the telemetry range performance, power monitoring accuracy against live hardware, and full avionics integration prior to the pop test.

5 Conclusion

This interim report presented the development progress of a reliable dual recovery system for the N4 rocket mission. The work addressed the three core problem areas established in the proposal: telemetry range limitations, uncontrolled deployment-wire heating, and lack of pre-flight status visibility.

5.1 Summary of Achievements

The following milestones have been achieved during the interim phase:

- Completion of literature review and identification of critical research and implementation gaps relevant to the N4 mission.
- Completion of subsystem-level design for the electrical and mechanical architecture, including telemetry, ignition control, feedback monitoring, and deployment hardware.
- XBee-PRO 900HP hardware configured and bench-validated via XCTU pre-flight procedure; open-field range testing is scheduled for the next phase.
- Successful PWM ignition bench testing demonstrating reliable black-powder ignition at 70% duty cycle without nichrome burnout under repeated tests.
- Proteus BMS simulation validating voltage-monitoring circuit design; hardware accuracy testing pending PCB delivery.
- Procurement of major electronic components and progression of PCB/mechanical fabrication activities.

These achievements confirm that the design direction selected in the proposal is technically feasible and suitable for mission-level implementation.

5.2 Interim Findings

The evidence obtained so far supports three important findings:

1. The XBee-PRO 900HP platform is suitable for long-range N4 recovery telemetry requirements at the design and bench-configuration level; full range verification at 5 km will be completed during field-testing in the next phase.
2. PWM-based ignition provides a practical and safer alternative to direct DC dump for nichrome activation.
3. Integrating continuity and battery-status feedback is essential for launch-inhibit safety logic and operational readiness checks.

5.3 Project Status and Next Phase

At the close of this interim phase, the project has completed design and preliminary subsystem validation, with the next phase focusing on full integration, comprehensive ground testing, and flight-readiness verification. This progression is consistent with the original proposal objectives and keeps the project on track toward a validated N4 dual recovery system.

5.4 Overall Conclusion

The interim work demonstrates meaningful technical progress toward a robust and testable recovery system for the N4 rocket. The results to date indicate that the proposed architecture can meet mission performance and safety targets, subject to final integrated-system validation in the remaining project phase.

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A Appendix A: CAD Drawings with Title Blocks

The engineering drawings below were produced in SolidWorks and include the institution title block, part number, material specification, and revision level required for fabrication.

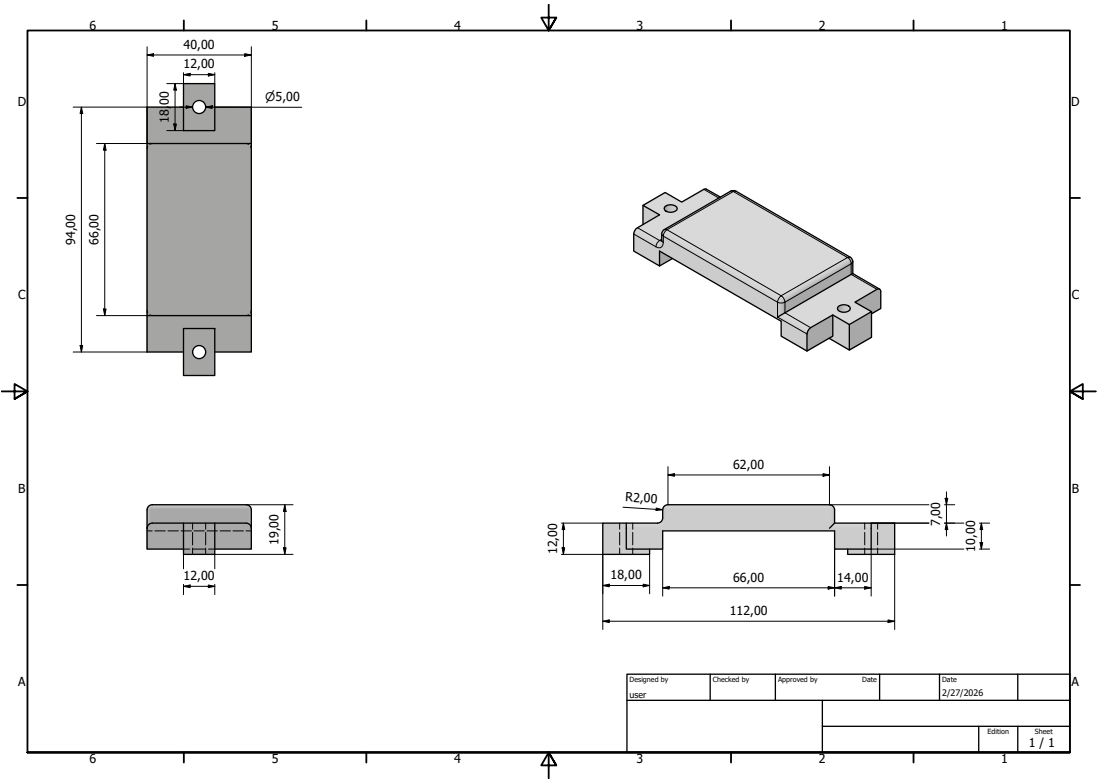


Figure 41: 18650 battery case cover – 2D manufacturing drawing with title block

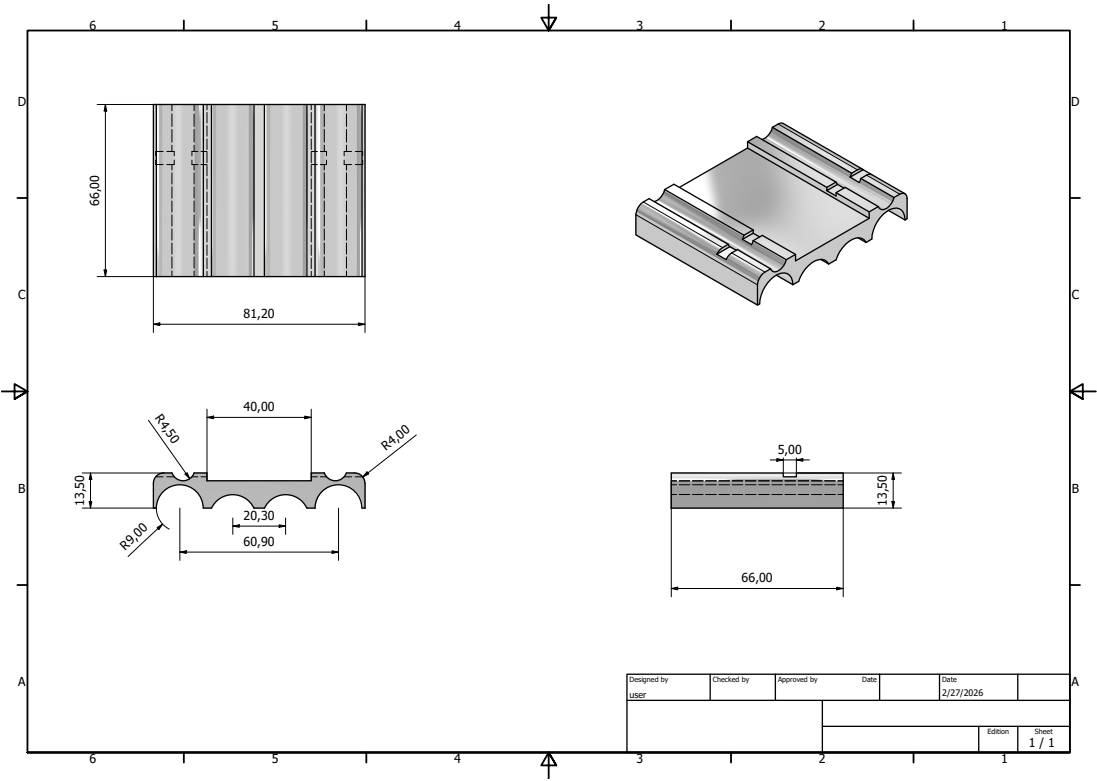


Figure 42: 18650 battery case body – 2D manufacturing drawing with title block

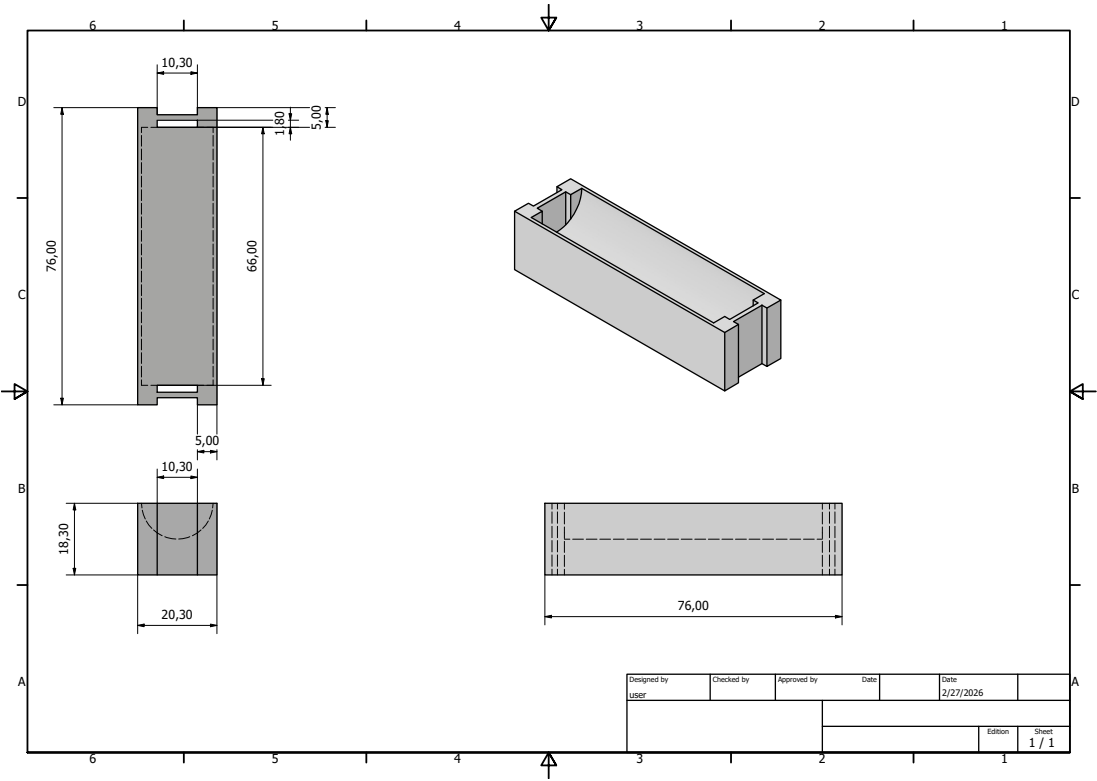


Figure 43: Edge battery support bracket – 2D manufacturing drawing with title block

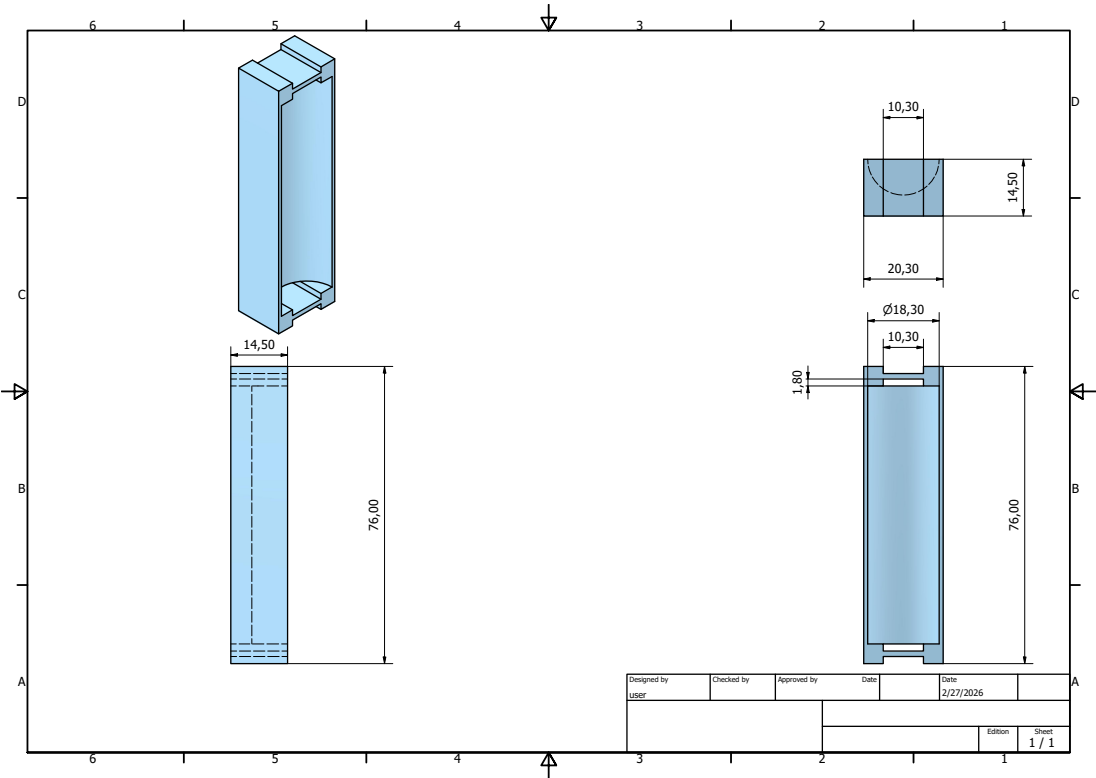


Figure 44: Mid battery support bracket – 2D manufacturing drawing with title block

B Appendix B: Flight Computer Circuit Design Reference

Figure 45 shows the current EasyEDA schematic for the flight computer, used as the design reference for PCB layout and component placement.

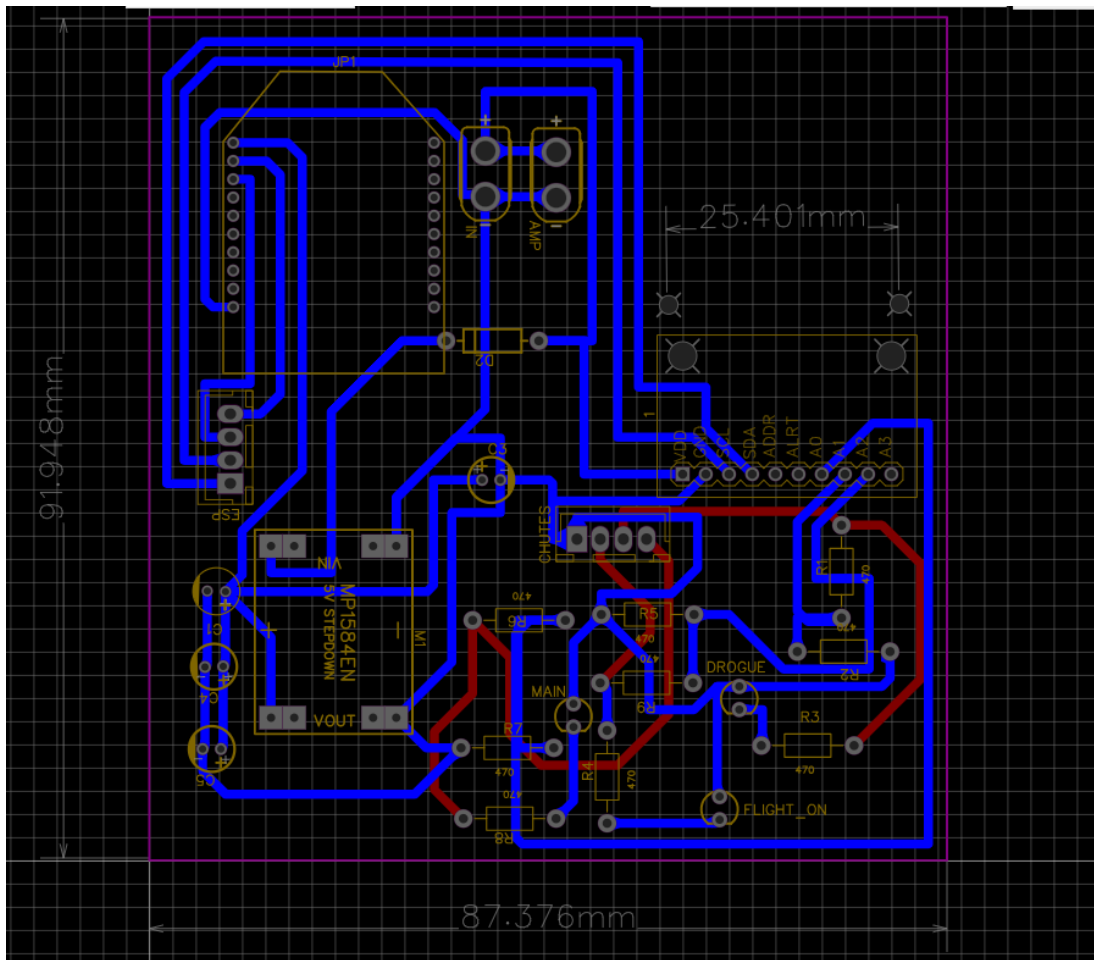


Figure 45: Current flight computer EasyEDA schematic – design reference for PCB fabrication (ESP32, XBee-PRO 900HP, power management, deployment circuitry)

C Appendix C: Project Budget

Table 13: Project Budget Breakdown

Item	Qty	Unit Cost (KES)	Total (KES)	Status
ESP32-WROOM-32	2	1800	3600	Received
XBee-PRO 900HP	2	4,500	9,000	Received
4S Lithium ion batteries (30000 mAh)	4	500	2000	Received
BMS Board (4S)	3	650	1,950	Received
IRLZ44N MOSFET	10	45	450	Received
Nichrome Wire (10 m)	1	500	500	Received
PCB Fabrication (5 pcs)	1	4,500	4,500	Fabrication
PCB Components (R, C, etc.)	1	2,000	2,000	Partial
PETG Filament (1 kg)	1	1,800	1,800	Received
Crimson Powder (100 g)	1	500	500	Pending
Connectors (XT60, JST, etc.)	1	1,200	1,200	Received
Fasteners and Hardware	1	800	800	Partial
Miscellaneous	1	1,500	1,500	–
Total Estimated Cost:			37,300	–

D Appendix D: Project Timeplan

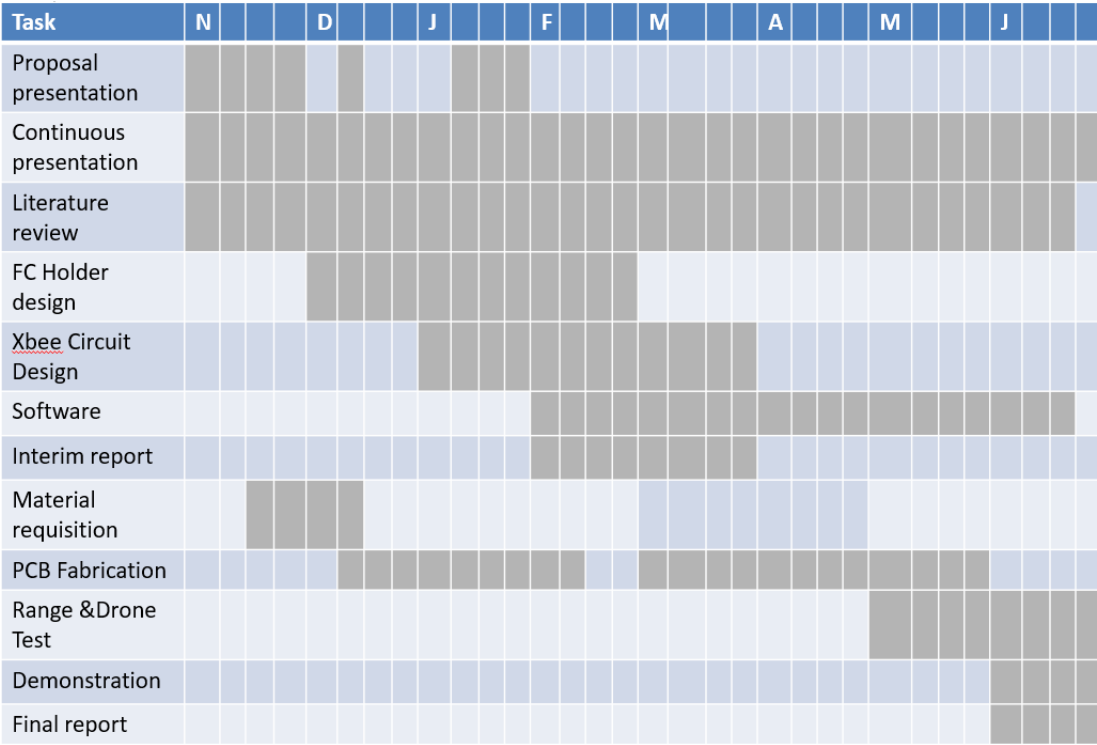


Figure 46: N4 recovery system project Gantt chart showing planned phases, milestones, and current progress